

TIME MACHINES
(clockwise from left) Echo Verse, Integer Study (drawing from life), and Epicycles

June 2, 1947."

There is little doubt Kallat and his art are both good keepers of time, but the histories they record are also sometimes more planetary than national. Showing at Chemould, 'Integer Studies' sees Kallat note three numbers with every abstract, geometric shape he draws: One number is the amount of people alive on the planet at the moment of drawing, and, alongside, is the number of people born that day, as also the people who have passed away. Kallat says binaries don't interest him. He doesn't want to brand himself optimistic or pessimistic, nor does he see any great value in tags like 'ecological' or 'existential': "All I know is intuition is not available to us always, and art is a way of getting close to it."

Kallat urges us to imagine stepping out onto the street. "And then think of yourself looking at the sky. Think of what it might be like to truly glimpse the stars. Now look back at the street a moment later. I would argue that your experience of the street would have transformed ever so slightly." Kallat is, of course, describing his own artistic process here. For him, working on 'Integer Studies', of just being present with those three numbers, often changed the microclimate of his studio. "Even if briefly, you are witness to intuition you do not otherwise have access to." The same can, strangely, be said for us, too. Kallat's work, at Chemould and Kochi, can change how we view ourselves and, perhaps, the stars. ■

Shreevatsa Nevatia

In the Frame

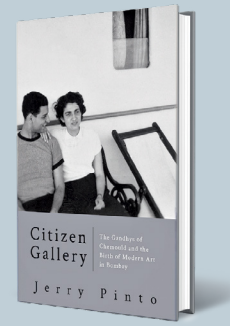
By telling the story of Khorshed and Kekoo Gandhy, Jerry Pinto adds to a vital chapter in the history of Indian art

A country's artistic power centres tend to shift from city to city across time. In modern India, Calcutta retained a primacy in the arts for over a 150 years, piggy-backing on the city being the colonial as well as the commercial capital of the subcontinent. Across the first half of the 20th century, Bombay wrestled away the commercial crown from Calcutta and by the time Independence came around, Bombay/ Mumbai/ Bambai was ready to start prising away the Cultural Capital tag from the City of Many Former Glories. Khorshed and Kekoo Gandhy, a wealthy Bombay Parsi couple (but not among the very wealthiest of wealthy Parsis, it has to be noted) became central to one major strand of the Bombay Ascendancy. Jerry Pinto's book tells the story of the Gandhys and Chemould, the art gallery they started.

K and K, as people close to them called them, were a power couple before the term was invented, and it seems they were one in the best, most gracious sense of the term. According to the narrative, Kekoo, the young scion of the Gandhys, tripped from one success to another, moving from a framing business based on wood-working to adding decorative chemical moulds to the frames (thus eventually the name Chem-Mould), to launching a posh framing shop in South Bombay, to finding interesting and unusual contemporary paintings to put into those frames. The last bit was what ultimately brought meaning and fame into the Gandhys' lives. K&K were open-minded people who moved in fluid, cosmopolitan circles that marked the elite of the newly independent country. European art teachers and critics introduced the young couple to a maverick group of penurious but talented young painters who called themselves the Progressives. The then unknown Raza, Souza, Husain, Gaitonde, Ara and others were to become the first stars of post-'47 Indian art; the Gandhys and their children would go on to support and represent succeeding generations of artists as well, and all this would provide the first great booster engine to contemporary visual art in our country.



THE GANDHYS
Khorshed and Kekoo with daughter Shireen



CITIZEN GALLERY: The Gandhys of Chemould and the Birth of Modern Art in Bombay
by Jerry Pinto
SPEAKING TIGER BOOKS
₹899; 328 pages

JERRY PINTO is particularly well placed to write the story of a family he is close to and a milieu to which he belongs

Jerry Pinto is one of our best writers and is particularly well placed to write the story of a family he is close to and a milieu to which he belongs. Moving between a familar tone and a quasi-forensic one, Pinto writes with warmth and admiration about K&K and with no little sadness at the loss of the generous, liberal, secular world constructed and inhabited by people like Kekoo and Khorshed.

Working with the couple's children (all now well into their own middle age), Pinto creates a portrait of husband and wife who seem to have genuinely complemented each other's qualities. Reading the book, one can't help but be aware of how fortunate and privileged these lives were; nor can one help noticing several occasions where Pinto slips from admiration into hagiography; none of this, however, takes away from the pleasure of following a fascinating and at times hilarious tale. ■

Ruchir Joshi